

Jack would give me one-word answers, and I'd scrawl random notes on scrap pieces of paper, throw them in my backpack and get the hell out of there.

Yet something changed on my last visit . . . Jack opened up and shared his hard-earned life lessons.

He told me what it was like to live through the Great Depression, when there often wasn't enough money for food.

He told me about the pain of outliving his son.

He told me about the day he lost his best friend—his wife of over 60 years.

He sat in his chair and confessed his biggest regrets to me, his last visitor: a schoolkid on an assignment.

'You're the only person who comes in to see him,' a nurse whispered to me as I left.

That really hit me.

Later that evening I sat at my desk and read through my notes. I wondered how I would have coped . . . *if* I would have coped. Compared to the genuine hardship, tragedy and poverty Jack had encountered, my life was a total cream puff.

Something clicked.

I realised I was in a position to do something very special for him—tell his story. So I began working hard on the piece. Harder than I'd ever worked on any assignment in my life. Not for the mark, but for the honour of helping someone.

And a week later, at parent-teacher night, my hard work paid off when the English teacher, Mr Ellison, delivered some bad news to my mother: 'I suspect Scott has copied this story of Jack from a book.'

After managing to convince him that I was for real, I ended up receiving an A (for perhaps the first *and last* time in my academic career).

But the real payoff was more profound: meeting Jack—and being able to perform a last act of kindness for him—was one of the pivotal moments of